Dispatch No. 1198 | 1 July 2026

Public confidence in Tanzania's judicial system is strong, but gaps in access to justice remain

Afrobarometer Dispatch No. 1198 | Jacqueline Mwaipopo and Brenda Mshumbushi

Summary

Access to justice for all is a cornerstone of democracy and good governance, empowering citizens to exercise their rights and hold leaders accountable (OECD, 2025). The Tanzanian government has affirmed its commitment to strengthening the rule of law and ensuring equal access to justice, in line with the United Nations' (2015) Sustainable Development Goal 16 (United Republic of Tanzania, 2019).

In 2024, the government introduced a new criminal-justice policy aimed at strengthening justice delivery through enhanced coordination among criminal-justice institutions, expansion of the national prosecution office, integration of information and communication technology systems across justice-sector agencies, and greater application of the rule of law at a subnational level (Mosenda, 2024).

Complementing these reforms, the judiciary has sought to expand access to judicial services across the country, reduce case backlogs, improve infrastructure, and increase public awareness of rights and legal-aid services. Recent initiatives include recruiting additional magistrates, expanding the network of primary courts at district and community levels, and promoting alternative dispute-resolution mechanisms to make justice more efficient and affordable (Moltmann-Willisch, 2025). Recent digitisation initiatives, including the automation of case-management systems, court proceedings, and translation services, are also intended to reduce delays and improve service delivery (Judiciary of Tanzania, 2023).

Despite these initiatives, significant challenges remain. On the World Justice Project's (2025) Rule of Law Index, Tanzania ranks 98th out of 143 countries, with comparatively stronger scores on order and security and on constraints on government powers, but lower performance on government openness and fundamental rights. Access to justice continues to be constrained by case backlogs, delays in court proceedings, and uneven access to judicial services. As of June 2024 the Court of Appeal alone had 5,900 pending cases, of which 1,248 had been unresolved for more than two years (Judiciary of Tanzania, 2024).

This dispatch reports findings from a special survey module on access to justice included in Afrobarometer's Round 10 surveys.

Results show that while a majority of Tanzanians express confidence that ordinary people can obtain justice in the courts, significant minorities remain concerned about the affordability of taking a case to court, as well as the fairness and timeliness of judgements. Awareness of legal-aid services is also limited.

Most Tanzanians trust the courts, though a majority perceive corruption among at least "some" judges and magistrates.

Six in 10 citizens would rather turn to political leaders than to formal courts to resolve disputes. And substantial minorities express concerns about unequal treatment under the law, political influence in judicial decisions, and impunity for public officials who commit crimes.

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Afrobarometer surveys

Afrobarometer is a pan-African, nonpartisan survey research network that provides reliable data on African experiences and evaluations of democracy, governance, and quality of life. Ten survey rounds in up to 45 countries have been completed since 1999. Round 10 surveys (2024/2025) cover 38 countries. Afrobarometer's National Partners conduct face-to-face interviews in the language of the respondent's choice.

The Afrobarometer team in Tanzania, led by REPOA, interviewed a nationally representative sample of 2,400 adult Tanzanians in June-July 2024. A sample of this size yields country-level results with a margin of error of +/-2 percentage points at a 95% confidence level. Previous surveys were conducted in Tanzania in 2001, 2003, 2005, 2008, 2012, 2014, 2017, 2021, and 2022.

Key findings

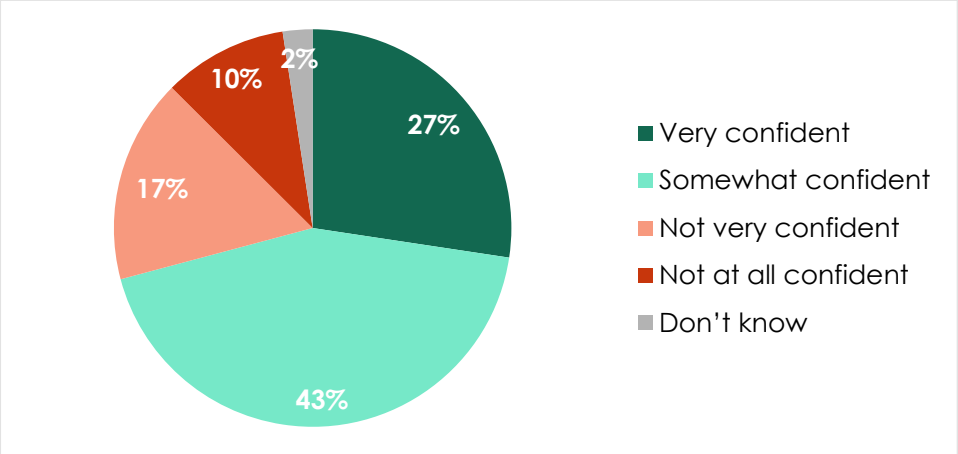
- Seven in 10 Tanzanians (71%) say they feel "somewhat confident" or "very confident" that ordinary people who are wronged can obtain justice in the courts,.
- Majorities of citizens consider it "somewhat likely" or "very likely" that they could find legal advice (64%) and could afford to obtain it (56%).
    - More than half believe they could afford to take a legal problem to court (58%) and would obtain a fair resolution (56%), but fewer than half (47%) are confident that such a case would be resolved within a reasonable time.
    - Only about one in three respondents (35%) say they are aware of legal-aid services available in their community.
- Six in 10 Tanzanians (59%) say they would turn to a political leader to help resolve a legal problem, while smaller shares would turn to the police (12%), government officials (9%), and local courts (5%).
- An overwhelming majority (84%) of citizens say they trust the courts "somewhat" or "a lot."
- Yet a solid majority (63%) think that "some," "most," or "all" judges and magistrates are corrupt.
- Seven in 10 Tanzanians (71%) say punishments for ordinary people who break the law are "about right."
    - More than one in four (27%) believe powerful individuals often face lighter consequences than they should.
    - About three in 10 say that officials who commit crimes "often" or "always" go unpunished (30%) and that people are frequently treated unequally under the law (28%).
- Most Tanzanians (76%) say the president must always obey the law and courts, and must regularly report to Parliament about taxpayers' money (80%).
    - Confidence is high that the president respects judicial decisions (82%) and Parliament's authority (83%).
- More than half (59%) of survey participants support the death penalty for the most serious crimes, though a significant minority (39%) say it can never be justified.

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Do the courts provide justice?

In Tanzania, confidence in the justice system is relatively high: Seven in 10 (71%)[1] say they are "somewhat confident" (43%) or "very confident" (27%) that ordinary people who are wronged can obtain justice in the courts (Figure 1). About one in four (27%) express little or no confidence.

Figure 1: Can people obtain justice in the courts? | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *In general, how confident are you that ordinary citizens who are wronged can obtain justice in the courts?*

More men (73%) than women (69%) expect that the courts will dispense justice (Figure 2). Faith in the courts rises as respondents' educational status increases (from 64% among the unschooled to 79% among those with post-secondary education) and falls with greater material deprivation[2] (from 77% among the well-off to 64% among the very poor).

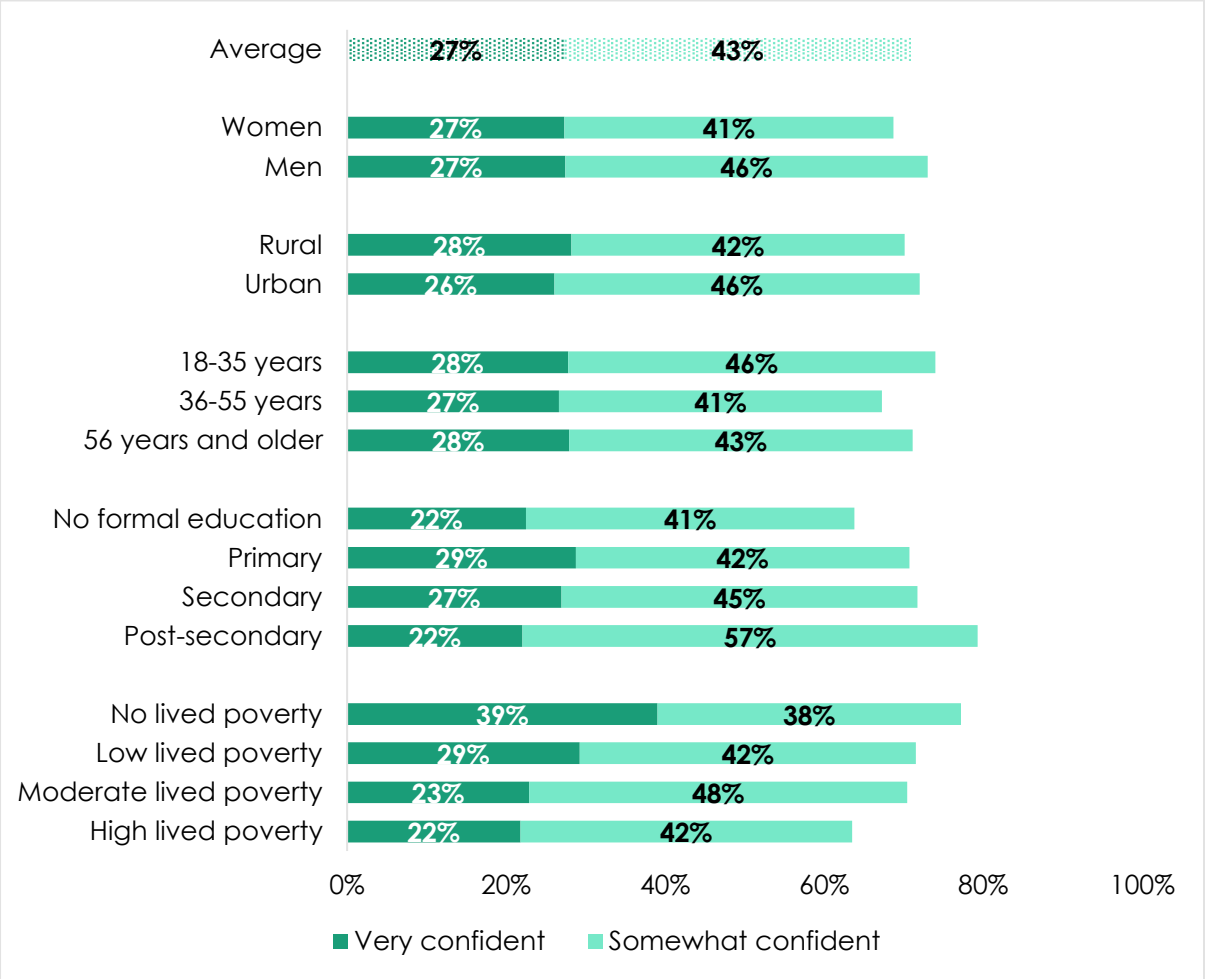
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[1] Due to rounding, percentages for combined categories reported in the text may differ slightly from the sum of sub-categories shown in figures (e.g. 43% "somewhat confident" and 27% "very confident" sum to 71%).

[2] Afrobarometer's Lived Poverty Index (LPI) measures respondents' levels of material deprivation by asking how often they or their families went without basic necessities (enough food, enough water, medical care, enough cooking fuel, and a cash income) during the preceding year. For more on lived poverty, see Mattes and Lekalake (2025).

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Figure 2: Confidence that people can obtain justice in the courts | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *In general, how confident are you that ordinary citizens who are wronged can obtain justice in the courts?*

Access to courts and legal services

Affordability, fairness, and timeliness are essential dimensions of effective access to justice. When asked whether they could afford to take a case to court should the need arise, more than half (58%) of Tanzanians say it is "somewhat likely" or "very likely" that they would be able to, though 39% consider it unlikely (Figure 3). Similarly, 56% believe they could receive a fair resolution in court. Timeliness is a greater challenge: Fewer than half (47%) think cases are likely to be resolved within a reasonable period, compared to 45% who think this is unlikely.

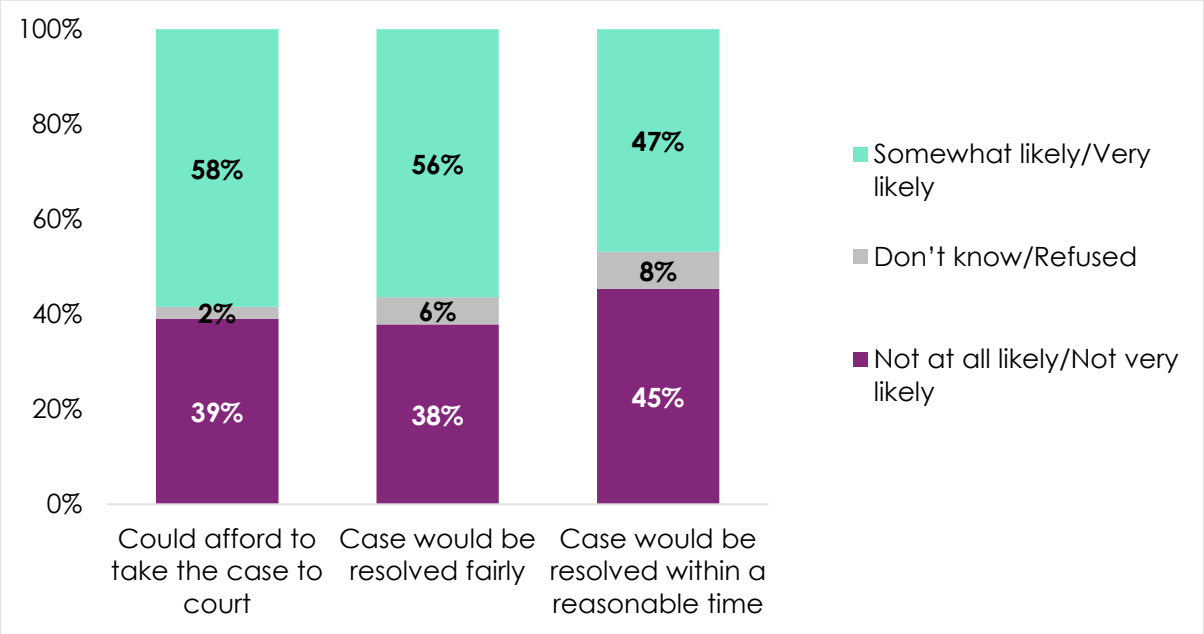
Men are slightly more confident than women that a court resolution would be fair (60% vs. 53%) and timely (49% vs. 45%) (Figure 4). Belief in a fair and timely court case declines with age.

Education and wealth are strongly associated with optimism: Tanzanians with post-secondary education are more likely than their less-educated peers to say a legal suit would likely be resolved fairly (81% vs. 49%-58%), as are the well-to-do compared to their poorer counterparts (72% vs. 47%-60%).

Similar patterns apply to prospects of a timely resolution, albeit with smaller margins.

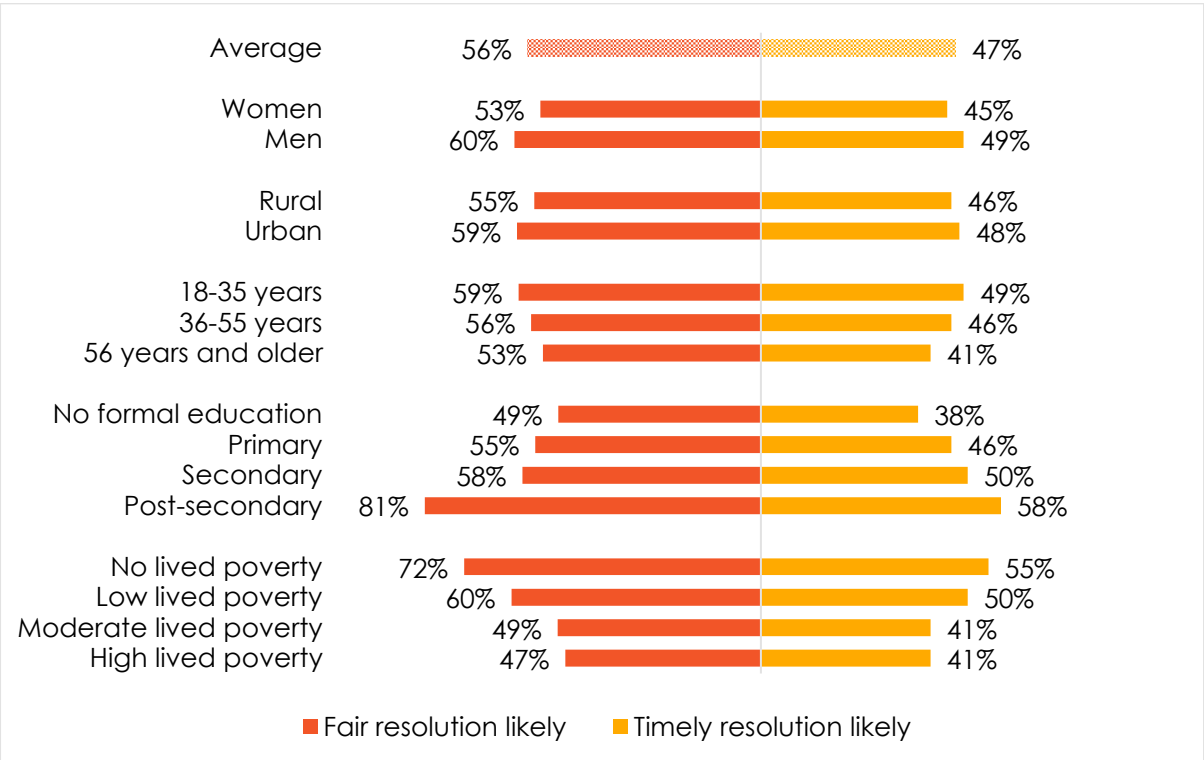
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Figure 3: Expectations regarding a court case | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *If you had a case that needed to go to court, how likely do you think it is that: You could afford to take the case to court? The case could be resolved in a reasonable amount of time? You could get a fair resolution in the courts?*

Figure 4: Likelihood of fair and timely resolution of a court case | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



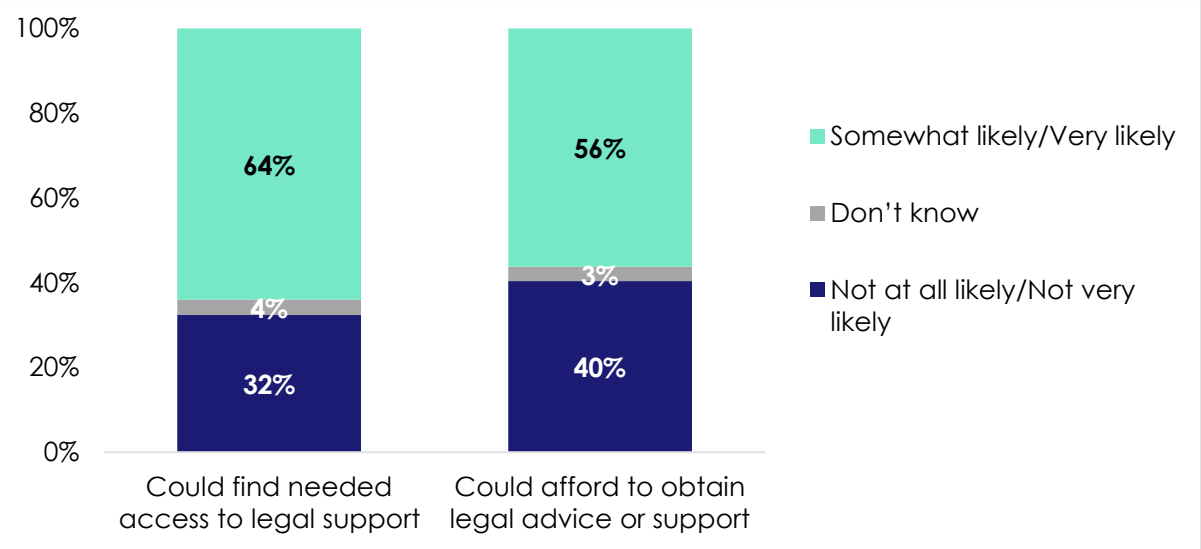
Respondents were asked: *If you had a case that needed to go to court, how likely do you think it is that: The case could be resolved in a reasonable amount of time? You could get a fair resolution in the courts? (% who say "somewhat likely" or "very likely")*

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Ordinary people who want to take a case to court will likely require advice or support from lawyers or legal services. Do Tanzanians think they can identify and afford such support?

Nearly two-thirds (64%) of citizens say it is "somewhat likely" or "very likely" that they could find needed legal support, while a slightly smaller majority (56%) believe they could afford it (Figure 5). But sizeable minorities are doubtful: 32% say they would struggle to find support, and 40% say they doubt they would be able to afford it.

Figure 5: Ability to find and afford legal support | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *If you had a legal problem such as a serious complaint against a business or member of your community, how likely do you think it is that: You could find the advice or support you need from lawyers or legal services to address or resolve the problem? You could afford to obtain the legal advice or support that you need?*

Financial barriers remain significant. About half of adults with no formal education say they would probably not be able to afford a court case (52%) or necessary legal support (49%), while nearly half of very poor respondents say the same (47% and 45%, respectively) (Figure 6). Both views decline with increases in educational attainment and living standards.

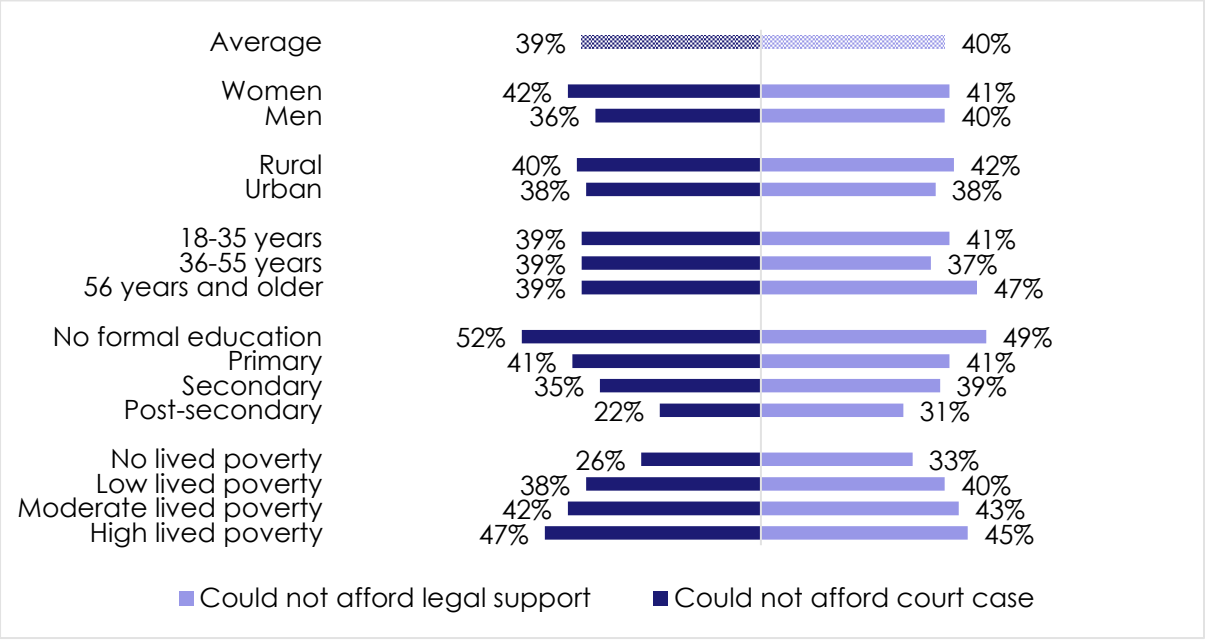
All age groups are equally likely to say that it is "not very likely" or "not at all likely" that they would be able to pay for a court case (39%), but more senior citizens (47%) than younger Tanzanians (37%-41%) think legal support would be too expensive.

Only about one-third (35%) of Tanzanians report knowing of legal-aid services in their community (Figure 7). Awareness is lowest among citizens with no formal education (22%), and rises to 50% among those with post-secondary schooling.

More urbanites (40%) and men (39%) are familiar with legal-aid services than rural residents (32%) and women (32%).

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Figure 6: Could not afford court case and legal support | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



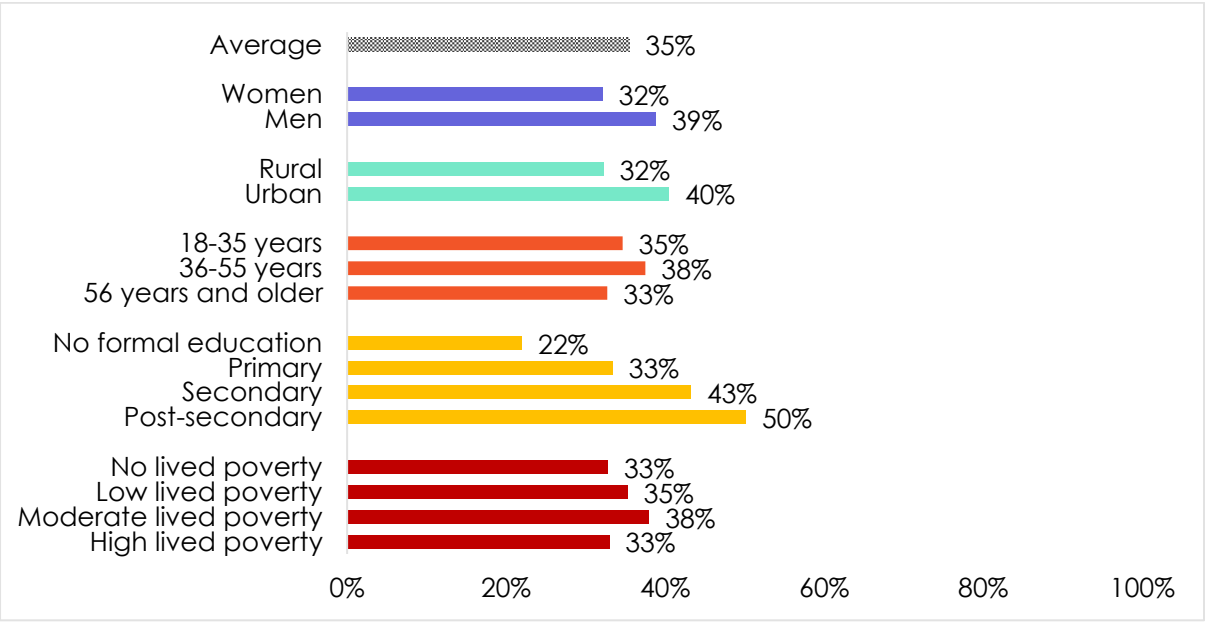
Respondents were asked:

If you had a legal problem such as a serious complaint against a business or member of your community, how likely do you think it is that you could afford to obtain the legal advice or support that you need?

If you had a case that needed to go to court, how likely do you think it is that you could afford to take the case to court?

(% who say "not very likely" or "not at all likely")

Figure 7: Awareness of legal-aid services | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *Are you aware of any legal-aid services available to you and others in your community? (% "yes")*

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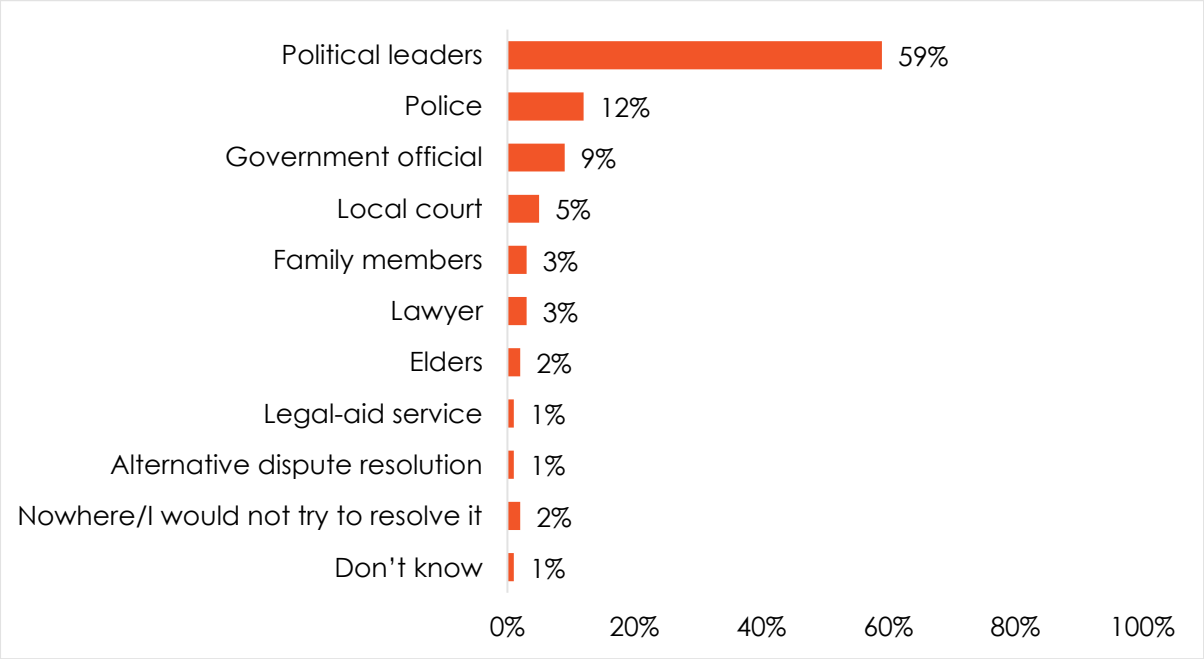
Preferred avenues for resolving disputes

Asked where they would go to resolve a legal problem such as a serious complaint against a business or a fellow member of their community, about six in 10 would approach political leaders (59%) (Figure 8).

Tanzania is an outlier in this regard: Across 38 African countries surveyed in 2024/2025, Madagascar recorded the next-highest proportion of respondents who would turn to politicians for help with legal issues (29%), followed by Benin (22%) and Uganda (17%).

Small minorities of Tanzanians would rather turn to the police (12%), government officials (9%), or a local court (5%), while even fewer would consult family members (3%), a lawyer (3%), or traditional leaders (2%).

Figure 8: Where to go to resolve a legal problem | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *If you had a legal problem such as a serious complaint against a business or member of your community, where would you be most likely to go to try to find a resolution?*

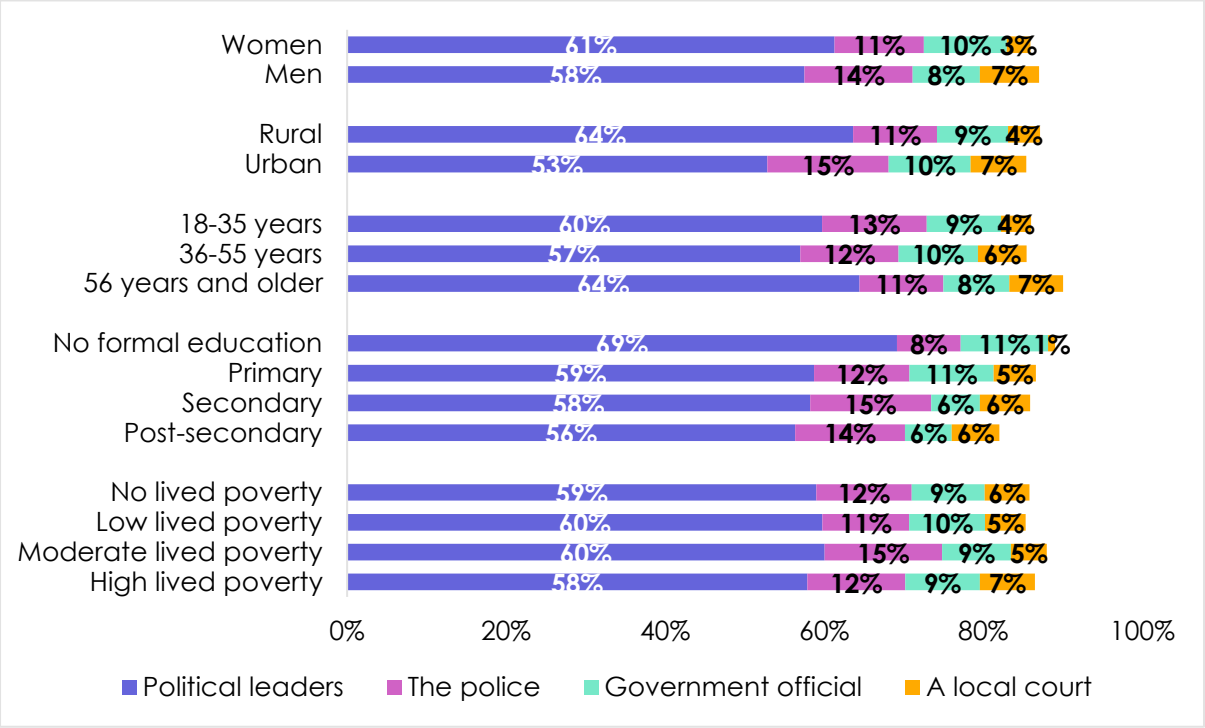
Looking at key demographic groups, majorities consistently prefer getting their legal problems resolved by political leaders (Figure 9). Rural residents are more likely than their urban counterparts to turn to them (64% vs. 53%), as are uneducated respondents compared to citizens with some level of formal education (69% vs. 56%-59%).

Citizens with at least secondary schooling are more likely than their their less-educated peers to head to the police and less likely to approach a government official.

Lived poverty has little bearing on respondents' preferences.

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Figure 9: Where to go to resolve a legal problem | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *If you had a legal problem such as a serious complaint against a business or member of your community, where would you be most likely to go to try to find a resolution?*

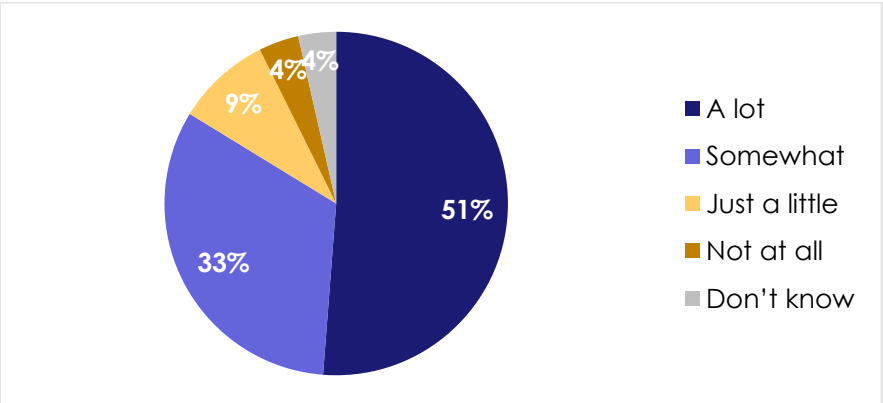
Integrity, independence, and neutrality of the judiciary

In addition to issues of access, cost, and expectations of a fair and timely resolution, people's trust in the judiciary may influence their willingness to engage with the court system. How confident are Tanzanians in the integrity of the system and the judges they would face?

Trust in the court system

An overwhelming majority (84%) of Tanzanians say they trust the courts "somewhat" (33%) or "a lot" (51%) (Figure 10). About one in eight (13%) express little or no trust.

Figure 10: Trust in courts of law | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *How much do you trust each of the following, or haven't you heard enough about them to say: Courts of law?*

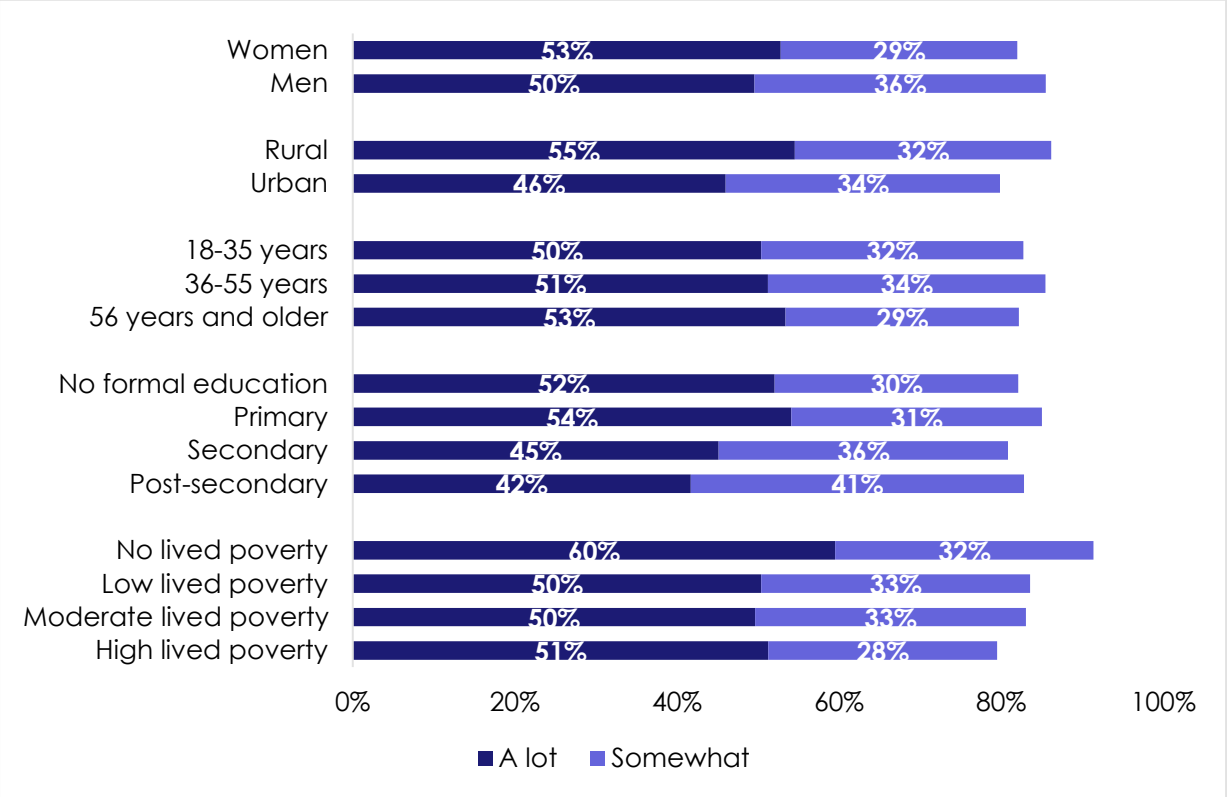
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Nine in 10 well-off respondents (91%) voice confidence in the judiciary, compared to 80%-84% among poorer citizens (Figure 11). Trust is higher among men (86%) and rural residents (86%) than women (82%) and urban residents (80%).

Education and age show no clear patterns.

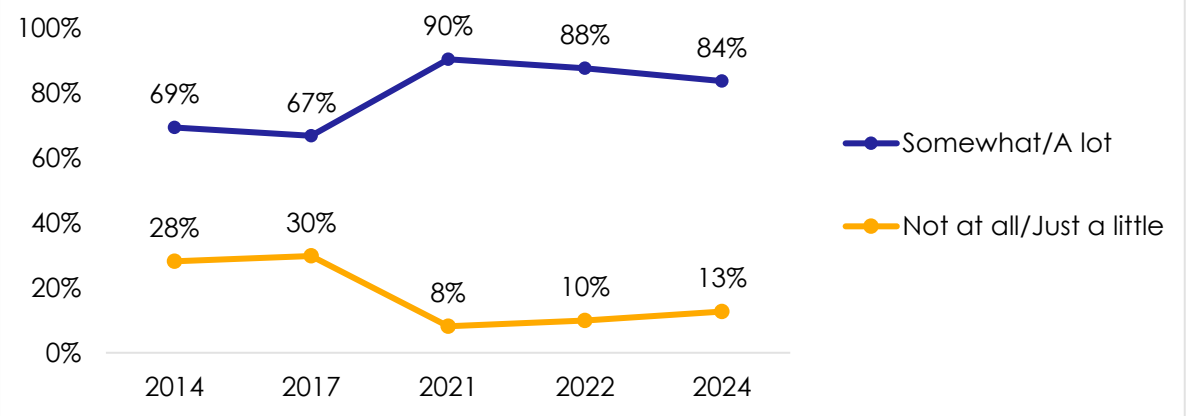
Trust in the courts is significantly higher than it was a decade ago (Figure 12). After holding steady between 2014 (69%) and 2017 (67%), trust levels increased sharply to 90% in 2021 before declining slightly in subsequent surveys.

Figure 11: Trust in courts of law | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *How much do you trust each of the following, or haven't you heard enough about them to say: Courts of law?*

Figure 12: Trust in courts of law | Tanzania | 2014-2024



Respondents were asked: *How much do you trust each of the following, or haven't you heard enough about them to say: Courts of law?*

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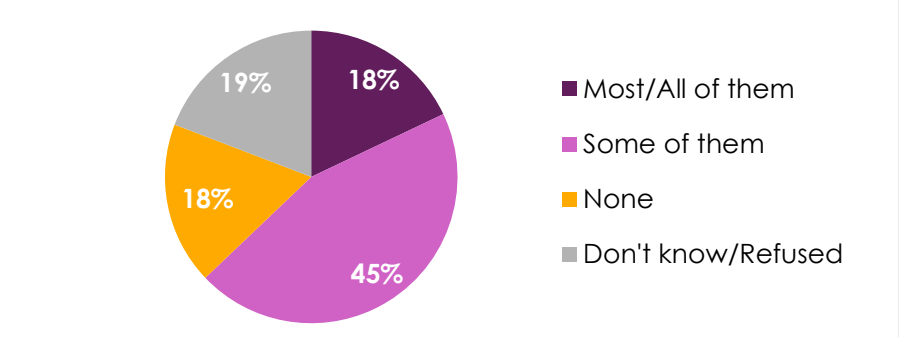
Perceived corruption in the courts

While public trust is high, there are concerns about judicial corruption. More than six in 10 citizens (63%) believe that at least "some" judges and magistrates are corrupt, including 18% who think "most" or "all" of them are (Figure 13). Similar proportions say there are no corrupt judges (18%) or express uncertainty (19%).

Perceptions of at least "some" judicial corruption rise to two-thirds or more among citizens with secondary (70%) or post-secondary (70%) education, men (68%), urban residents (68%), and respondents experiencing high lived poverty (67%) (Figure 14).

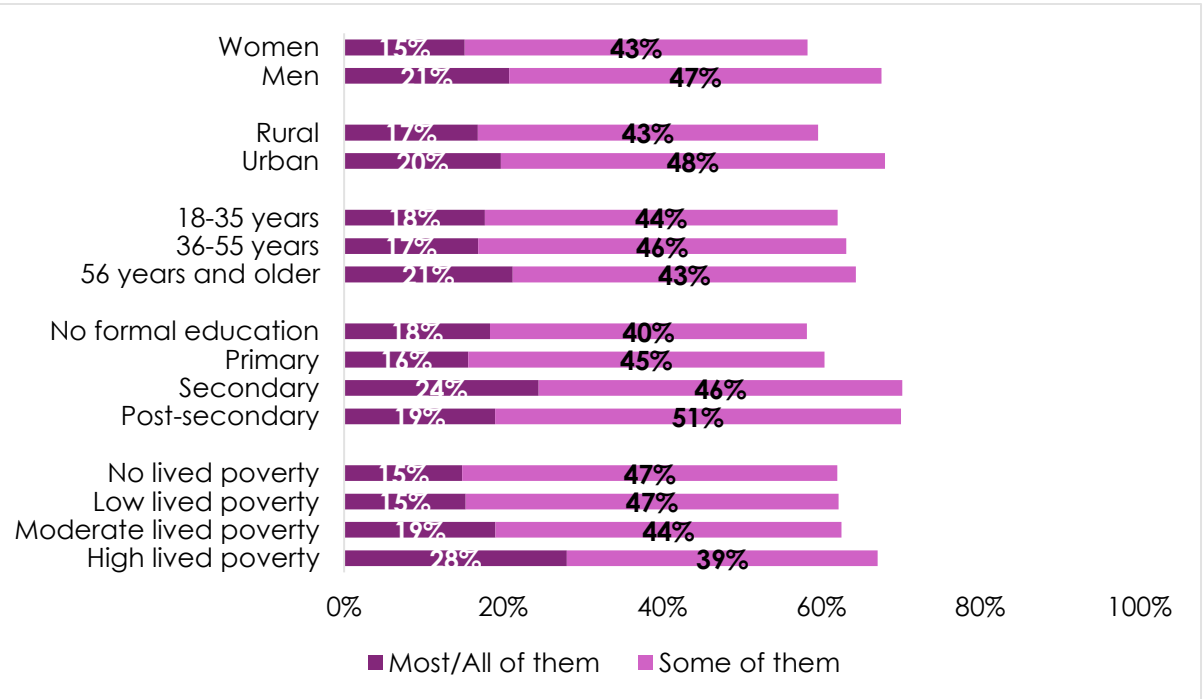
Perceptions of widespread corruption are less prevalent than they were a decade ago: The share of Tanzanians who believe that "most" or "all" judges and magistrates are corrupt declined from 36% in 2014 to 18% in 2024 (Figure 15). But the share who think at least "some" judicial officers are involved in graft is up by 13 percentage points since 2021 (50%).

Figure 13: Perceived corruption among judges and magistrates | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *How many of the following people do you think are involved in corruption, or haven't you heard enough about them to say: Judges and magistrates?*

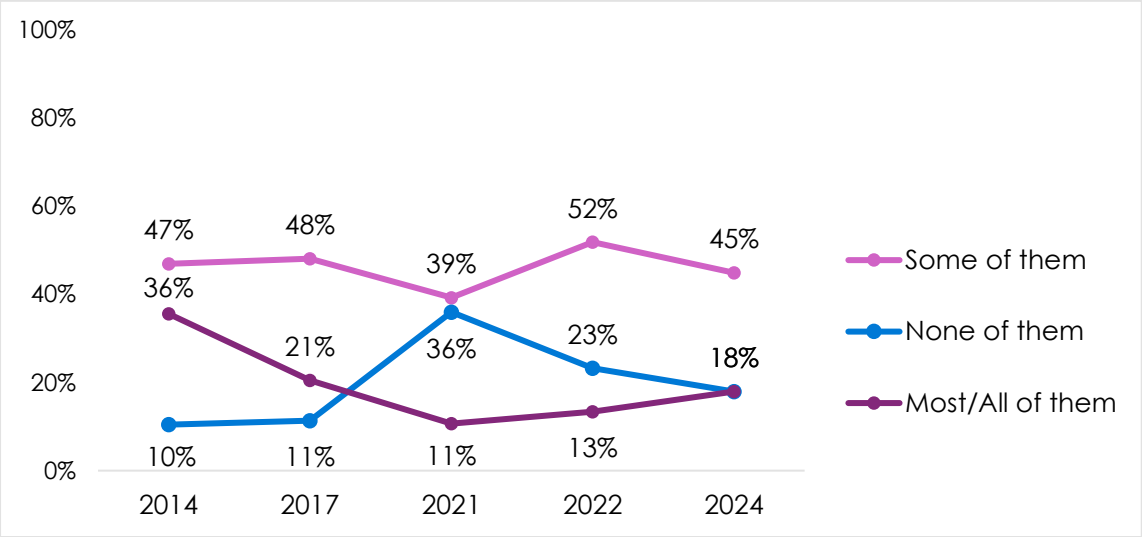
Figure 14: Perceived corruption among judges and magistrates | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *How many of the following people do you think are involved in corruption, or haven't you heard enough about them to say: Judges and magistrates?*

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Figure 15: Perceived corruption among judges and magistrates | Tanzania | 2014-2024



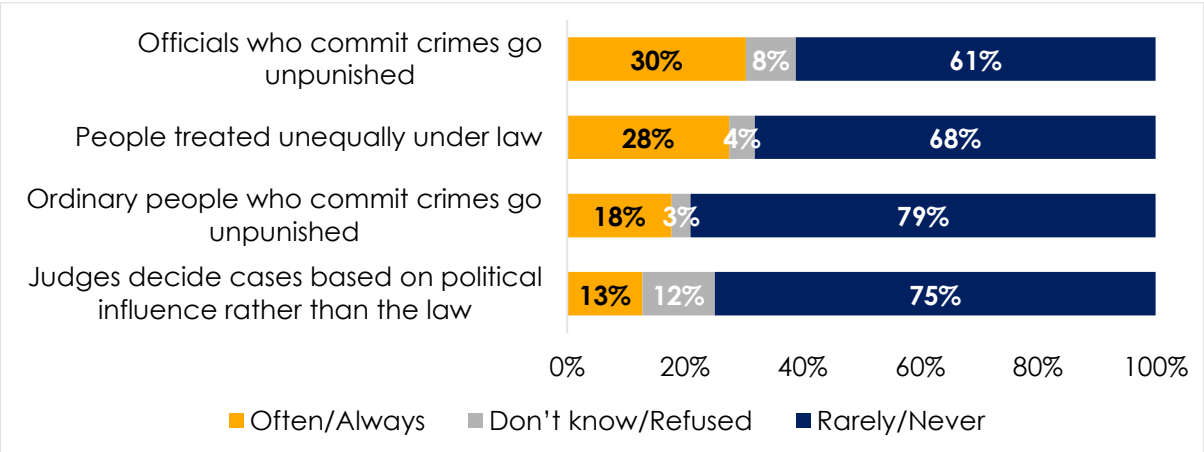
Respondents were asked: *How many of the following people do you think are involved in corruption, or haven't you heard enough about them to say: Judges and magistrates?*

Independence and neutrality of the courts

Tanzania's Constitution establishes the independence of the judiciary. It also guarantees equality before the law, stating that "no person shall be discriminated against… on the basis of their nationality, tribe, place of origin, political opinion, colour, religion, sex or station in life" (United Republic of Tanzania, 1977).

Tanzanians broadly perceive equal application of the law: Large majorities say that it is "rarely" or "never" the case that ordinary people who commit crimes go unpunished (79%), that judges are influenced by powerful people when deciding cases (75%), and that people are treated unequally under the law (68%) (Figure 16). And while three in 10 respondents (30%) say officials who commit crimes "often" or "always go unpunished, 61% disagree.

Figure 16: Equality under the law | Tanzania | 2024

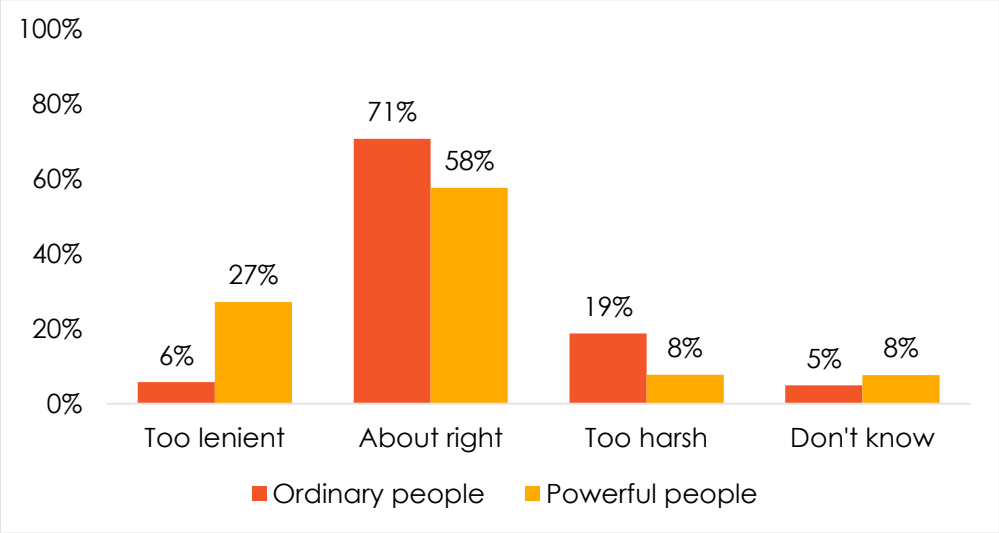


Respondents were asked: *In your opinion, how often, in this country: Do judges and magistrates decide cases based on the influence of political leaders, government officials, or other powerful people, rather than based on the law? Are people treated unequally under the law? Do officials who commit crimes go unpunished? Do ordinary people who break the law go unpunished?*

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When asked about sentencing, 71% say punishments for ordinary people who break the law are appropriate, while 19% say they are too harsh and 6% say they are too lenient (Figure 17). A majority (58%) also believe that penalties for powerful people who commit crimes are "about right." But the share who say elites get off lightly is 21 percentage points higher than for ordinary folks (27% vs. 6%).

Figure 17: Severity of penalties for crimes (ordinary people vs. powerful people) | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked:

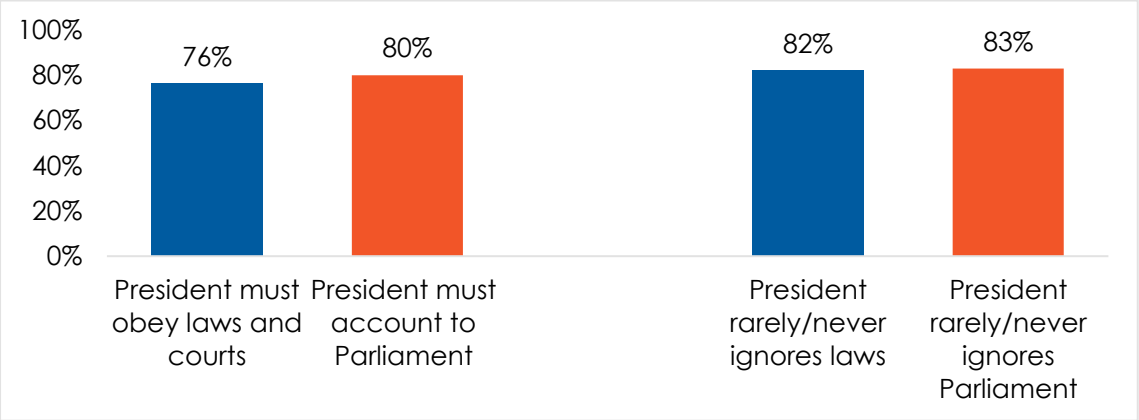
In general, when ordinary people are convicted of crimes in this country, do you think that the punishments handed down to them, such as fines or jail or prison sentences, are too harsh, too lenient, or generally about right, or haven't you heard enough to say?
In general, when political leaders, government officials, or other powerful people are convicted of crimes in this country, do you think that the punishments handed down to them, such as fines or jail or prison sentences, are too harsh, too lenient, or generally about right, or haven't you heard enough to say?

Executive respect for the rule of law

Tanzanians strongly support presidential respect for the rule of law: More than three-quarters agree that the president must obey the laws and courts even if she thinks they are wrong (76%) and that she must regularly report to Parliament about how taxpayers' money is spent (80%) (Figure 18). And overwhelming majorities say President Samia Suluhu Hassan "rarely" or "never" ignores laws (82%) and Parliament (83%).

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Figure 18: Presidential respect for the rule of law | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked:

Which of the following statements is closest to your view?
Statement 1: Since the president was elected to lead the country, she should not be bound by laws or court decisions that she thinks are wrong.
Statement 2: The president must always obey the laws and the courts, even if she thinks they are wrong.
(% who agree with Statement 2)

Which of the following statements is closest to your view?
Statement 1: Parliament should ensure that the president explains to it on a regular basis how her government spends taxpayers' money.
Statement 2: The president should be able to devote her full attention to developing the country rather than wasting time justifying her actions.
(% who agree with Statement 1)

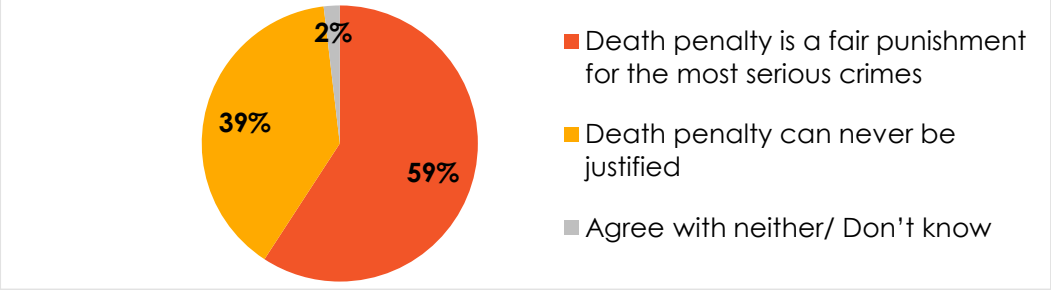
In your opinion, how often, in this country: Does the president ignore the courts and laws of this country? Does the president ignore Parliament and just do what she wants?

Views on the death penalty

Although Tanzania retains the death penalty in law for certain serious offences, no executions have been carried out since 1994. Successive governments have maintained this practice, and many death sentences have been commuted to life imprisonment. Nonetheless, high courts continue to impose the death penalty to dozens of convicts each year (Wazambi, 2023).

Citizens are tolerant of capital punishment: 59% say the death penalty is justified for the most serious crimes (Figure 19). But 39% say it is never justified.

Figure 19: Views on the death penalty | Tanzania | 2024

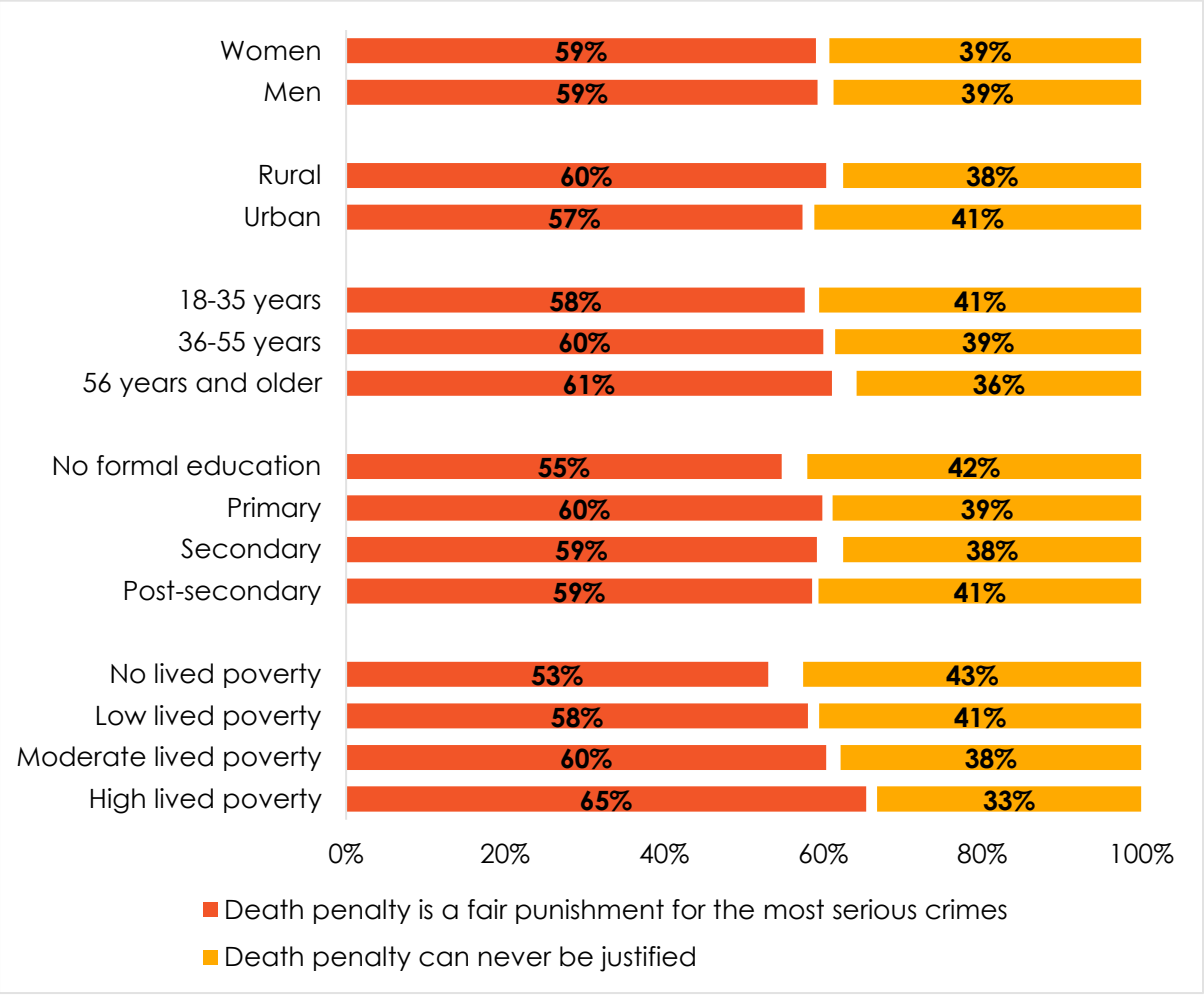


Respondents were asked: *Which of the following statements is closest to your view?*
Statement 1: The death penalty is a fair punishment for people who have committed the most serious crimes, such as murder.
Statement 2: There is no crime for which the death penalty can be justified.

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Views about the acceptability of the death penalty are consistent across most major demographic groups, with few differences by gender, urban-rural location, age, or education status (Figure 20). Endorsement rises from a slim majority (53%) of well-off respondents to nearly two-thirds (65%) among the very poor.

Figure 20: Views on the death penalty | by demographic group | Tanzania | 2024



Respondents were asked: *Which of the following statements is closest to your view?*
Statement 1: The death penalty is a fair punishment for people who have committed the most serious crimes, such as murder.
Statement 2: There is no crime for which the death penalty can be justified.

Conclusion

Afrobarometer survey data show that although Tanzania's judicial system enjoys widespread trust, it still faces key challenges. A majority of citizens believe that at least some judges and magistrates are involved in corruption, and substantial minorities express doubts about their ability to afford to take a case to court. Meanwhile, only about one in three respondents are aware of legal-aid services in their community.

Roughly three in 10 worry that officials who commit crimes go unpunished and that people are treated unequally under the law. And while many citizens believe they could obtain necessary legal support and receive a fair outcome if they went to court, fewer than half are confident that a case would be resolved in a timely fashion.

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Strong levels of trust in courts, confidence in the judiciary's ability to dispense justice in cases of wrongdoing, and a general perception that the president respects other branches of government provide a solid foundation for access to justice and respect for the rule of law. Addressing delays, expanding access to affordable legal aid, and clamping down on corruption in the judicial system could make justice more inclusive and further strengthen public confidence.

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